Before he could get near me, someone took him away. There was no sign of DIG Siby Mathews. Whenever I asked for the officer, policemen said he was on the way. In the evening, a policeman came and asked me what food I wanted. I said nothing. I felt like having a smoke. I had quit smoking in 1991, before which I used to smoke about forty cigarettes a day. 'I need a packet of cigarettes,' I said.

'Which brand?'

'Get me a pack of Wills.'

The policeman came with the cigarettes and I started chain-smoking. I could hear in bits and pieces policemen discussing the ISRO spy case. I heard the names Mariam Rasheeda and Sasikumaran. Then I heard someone mentioning my name. Someone brought a biryani which I refused to eat. I had water. I smoked. I felt like asking for a drink, but decided against it. Nobody came till nightfall, and I slept on the bench. I dreamt of my father.

KAMARAJ AND KINETICS

A giant comes to campus, a teacher shows anything is possible.

Mathematicians think they can solve any problem. And then, life intervenes with its absurd equations and cruel calculations. Being good at mathematics made me think I can anticipate, encounter and solve any problem. As for the unsolvable ones, I knew why there can't be an absolute solution, and hence should seek alternatives. This had kept me in good stead as a student, as a sugar factory employee, and later as a rocket scientist.

But fate did intervene in different ways; sometimes taking me to levels of confidence that bordered on arrogance, at others to black holes of emotions where suicide was a logical end, and then to a state of measured optimism, courageous fight back and composed indifference. Some call it the survival kit of a spy who never was. I call it life.